

Appendix C — Arabic/French error quick-reference card

Print this. Keep it beside the keyboard for every timed essay. It is a condensation of Chapter 8 §L1 alert, which is the canonical home of all of it — nothing here contradicts that chapter, and where you want the mechanism, the corpus evidence or more examples, go there.

The one-line version: fix articles and full stops before you fix anything clever.

1 · Articles — your single most expensive error

Both your languages push the same way. French *la société* and Arabic *al-mujtama'* both put an article on a generic noun; English uses the zero article. This is the largest measured band 6 → 7 discontinuity in the IELTS research literature — **18.4% error at band 6 falling to 7.4% at band 7**, with bands 5 and 6 not significantly different.

[src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019, IELTS Research Reports 2019/1 – Speaking data, L1 mix unreported]

The rule is not "avoid *the*". It is "no *the* with a generic."

✗ The society expects... → ✓ Society expects... ✗ Governments must invest in the education to reduce the poverty. → ✓ Governments must invest in education to reduce poverty.

But *the* comes straight back the moment the noun is made specific — by an *of*-phrase, a defining relative clause, a superlative, an ordinal, a date, or a second mention:

✓ **The* society** *in which we live* rewards specialists. ✓ **The number of students** · **The highest figure** · **The measures** *that were introduced****

⚠ THE COUNTER-LIST — abstract nouns that KEEP their article

Do not strip these. There is no principle behind the split; learn it as a list.

Take the in generic use	Take zero in generic use
the environment · the government · the media · the economy · the internet · the public · the police · the countryside · the weather · the climate · the authorities · the state · the past · the future · the elderly · the young	society · nature · technology · education · health · poverty · crime · unemployment · inflation · pollution · globalisation · tourism · agriculture · industry · science · history · art · music · life · knowledge · research · transport

✗ Environment is the main casualty... → ✓ **The environment is the main casualty**... ✗ **Media exaggerate the risks**... → ✓ The media exaggerate the risks...

Over-correction after this rule is taught is a real and predictable failure mode. If you find yourself deleting *the* from *the government*, stop and re-read this box.

The reverse error — the missing *a/an*

Arabic has **no indefinite article**, so the slot simply stays empty.

✗ Social media has great impact... → ✓ ...has a great impact... ✗ He works as engineer. → ✓ ...as an engineer. ✗ important for health of the body → ✓ ...for the health of the body (*the + N + of + N* is specific by definition)

Five patterns cover most of what you actually get wrong: *the + NOUN + of + NOUN* is almost always *the* · superlatives and ordinals take *the* · generic plural is zero however long the modifier · percentages and dates take no article (*in 2010, 20 per cent of students* — but *the percentage of, the 1990s*) · second mention takes *the*.

2 · The nine uncountables — the error that never resolves on its own

information · advice · research · equipment · feedback · knowledge · software · furniture · evidence

Never plural. Never *a/an*. French pluralises all of them; Arabic pluralises several.

This one gets a permanent checklist slot rather than a lesson. Overuse errors against the plural (*peoples, informations*) were the **only** error type the IELTS study found at **every** band level, explicitly reported as not resolving as proficiency rises. It survives to band 8. It will not fix itself with practice. [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 – Speaking data, L1 mix unreported]

✗	✓
<i>several informations</i>	<i>a good deal of information / several pieces of information</i>
<i>many useful advices</i>	<i>a great deal of useful advice / a piece of advice</i>
<i>Recent researches show</i>	<i>Recent research shows (the verb changes too) / Recent **studies show</i>
<i>modern equipments</i>	<i>modern equipment</i>
<i>the feedbacks they receive</i>	<i>the feedback they receive</i>
<i>technical knowledges</i>	<i>technical knowledge (but ✓ a working knowledge of statistics)</i>
<i>many evidences</i>	<i>considerable evidence / several findings**</i>
<i>expensive softwares</i>	<i>expensive software</i>
<i>second-hand furnitures</i>	<i>second-hand furniture</i>

And the one that is not on the list because it is not uncountable — **peoples** is a real word meaning ethnic groups, and it is never what you mean. *People* is already plural: ✗ *Peoples are depend on...* → ✓ *People depend on...*

3 · Prepositions — a closed list, so learn it as one

✗	✓	From
depend of	depend on	<i>dépendre de</i>
participate to	participate in	<i>participer à</i>
discuss about	discuss Ø (transitive)	<i>discuter de</i>
married with	married to	<i>marié avec</i>
arrive to the capital	arrive in a city/country, at a building/event	<i>arriver à</i>
interested by	interested in	<i>intéressé par</i>
responsible of / about	responsible for	<i>responsable de</i> / Arabic 'an
consist in	consist of	<i>consister en</i>
suffer of	suffer from	<i>souffrir de</i>
contributed on	contributed to	Arabic transfer
focuses in	focuses on	Arabic transfer
in the other hand	on the other hand	fixed phrase

And since vs for — French *depuis* and Arabic *mundhu* cover both. *Since* + a **point** in time · *for* + a **length** of time.
 ✗ *running since ten years* → ✓ *for ten years* · ✗ *risen for 2015* → ✓ *since 2015*

4 · False friends — these cost LR, not GRA, so clean grammar cannot offset them

You write	You mean	Write instead
<i>actually</i>	currently	at present , currently
<i>the actual situation</i>	the present one	the current situation
<i>eventually</i>	possibly	possibly , potentially
<i>assist to</i>	to attend	attend
<i>demand somebody to</i>	to ask	ask somebody to
<i>formation</i>	training	training
<i>sensible</i>	sensitive	sensitive
<i>deception</i>	disappointment	disappointment
<i>library</i> (for a shop)	bookshop	bookshop
<i>support</i>	to tolerate	tolerate , put up with
<i>achieve</i> (a dissertation)	to finish	complete , finish
<i>control</i>	to check/inspect	check , inspect
<i>significant</i>	— not an English word	significant
<i>inconvenient</i> (as a noun)	drawback	drawback , disadvantage
<i>stage</i>	internship	internship , placement
<i>permit to study</i>	— ungrammatical in every register	allow students to study / enable X to / make it possible to

That last row is grammar as well as vocabulary: English *permit* and *allow* need an **object** before the infinitive. If you cannot supply one, change the verb.

The false-friend five, for a 10-second scan: *actually* · *eventually* · *assist* · *permit to* · *significant*. Each is wrong more often than right in your writing.

5 · Full stops — comma splices and run-ons

Punctuation is inside GRA, so a splice is a grammar error that damages two clauses at once. Arabic prose builds by coordination (*wa-*, *fa-*) rather than subordination; French licenses a longer sentence. You get the length from one language and the chaining from the other.

✗ Public transport is cheap and it is used by many workers and it reduces traffic and it also reduces pollution and the government wants to expand it.

✓ Public transport in the capital is cheap and heavily used by workers. Because it takes cars off the road, it reduces both congestion and pollution — which is why the government intends to expand it.

The check: read only the commas. At each one, cover the left — is the right a complete sentence? Cover the right — is the left? Two complete sentences with a bare comma between them is a splice.

Repair with a subordinator if you can (*because, although, while, since, whereas*) — that converts an error into a complex structure. A full stop only if you cannot.

And the adverb trap: *however · therefore · moreover · thus · nevertheless* are adverbs. They **cannot** join two clauses. The mark before them must be a full stop or a semicolon, never a comma. *and · but · because · although · while* are conjunctions and can.

6 · Third-person -s — *occasional slip, not habitual omission*

The descriptors do permit a few basic errors to persist even at bands 7 and 8, so perfection is not required. But the measured collapse is from **70.6% error at band 6 to 7.6% at band 7** — the sharpest cliff of any morpheme. [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 – Speaking data, L1 mix unreported]

The tolerance is real once your rate is occasional, and not before. *A few* is a density claim; the official criteria rate accuracy on error density.

✗ Technology play an important role → ✓ Technology plays ✗ A child who spend three hours online read less → ✓ *A child who spends... reads less* — *the verb inside the relative clause agrees too, and that slot is the one usually missed* ✗ Each of the three regions have... → ✓ *...has... (each is singular; the plural in the *of*-phrase is a distractor)

Do not overcorrect collectives. *The government have decided...* is standard British English. Leave it.

And never stack two bare verbs: ✗ *peoples are depend*, ✗ *he do not works*, ✗ *the government are decide*.

7 · Arabic-only: the relative-clause pair

Modern Standard Arabic leaves a pronoun in the relative gap, and drops the relative marker after an indefinite head. So it predicts an **extra** pronoun *and* a **missing** one.

✗ The reform which the ministry announced it in 2019... → ✓ delete it ✗ The district where the council built the tramline in it... → ✓ delete in it ✗ There are many households live below the poverty line. → ✓ ...many households that live... / ...many households living below the poverty line.

Learn the last one first. The reduced-relative repair deletes a transfer error *and* produces a band-7 participle clause in the same stroke.

Copula omission — high severity, low frequency: ✗ *These measures very expensive* → ✓ *These measures are very expensive*.

8 · Register — the French habit that is a CC cost, not a GRA one

De plus · en outre · par ailleurs transfer into *Moreover* or *Furthermore* at the head of every paragraph. Band 6 names cohesion that is faulty or mechanical through misuse, **overuse** or omission.

Rule of thumb: if a linker could be deleted without the reader losing the thread, delete it. About two markers per paragraph, never zero.

And do not confuse elevation with precision:

✗ In the name of progress, it is of the utmost significance to recognise that the technology has become a fundamental pillar of the modern educational sector. ✓ Technology has become central to modern education.

Band 7 LR asks for awareness of style and collocation. It does not reward grandeur.

The timed sweeps — rehearse these until they are automatic

They only work under the clock if you have done them fifty times.

The 60-second Arabic sweep 1. **Every the (25 s)**. Is the noun after it an abstract idea in general, with no *of*-phrase, relative clause or superlative attached? Delete — **unless it is on the counter-list**. 2. **Every article-less singular noun (25 s)**. Needs *a/an* or *the*. Proper nouns exempt. 3. **Every which / who / where (10 s)**. Stray pronoun after the verb? Delete. Clause with no relative pronoun after an indefinite head? Insert *that*, or reduce to *-ing*.

The 45-second French sweep 1. **The nine words (15 s)**. Scan for any carrying an *-s*. Delete it, fix the verb behind it. 2. **Verb + preposition (15 s)**. depend **on** · participate **in** · discuss **Ø** · married **to** · arrive **in/at** · responsible **for** · interested **in** · consist **of** · suffer **from**. 3. **The false-friend five (10 s)**. *actually* · *eventually* · *assist* · *permit to* · *significant*. 4. **since / for (5 s)**. Point in time → *since*. Length of time → *for*.

The three-minute self-edit — Task 1 stop at **17 minutes**, Task 2 stop at **37 minutes**. Do not read for meaning; you will read what you meant, not what you wrote.

Pass 1 — full stops (60 s). §5 above. **Pass 2 — nouns (60 s)**. Nine uncountables with an *-s*? Generic *the*? Bare singular countable? Anything in the frame **___ of ___** (it almost certainly needs *the*)? **Pass 3 — verbs (45 s)**. Third-person *-s*, including inside relative clauses. Plural verb after people/governments/students. Two bare verbs stacked. A passive on an intransitive verb (was happened, was risen). **Pass 4 — your longest two or three sentences only (15 s)**. Although ... but? Delete *the* but. Despite + subject + verb? Participle clause — is the word right after the comma the thing doing the participle? which ... it? Would in an *if*-clause?

The rule that makes it work: in these three minutes you may delete and repair. You may not add. An untested complex sentence at minute 39 is the likeliest place for a faulty one to appear — and one faulty complex sentence reinstates the band-6 limiter you spent the whole essay avoiding.

Your error map, ranked by expected cost

At the 6 → 7 boundary both bands sit above the impede-communication line, so **severity is not what separates them — density is.**

#	Error	Criterion
1	Articles — generic <i>the</i> , missing <i>a/an</i> , missing <i>the</i> before <i>N of N</i>	GRA
2	Comma splices and run-ons	GRA (+CC)
3	Third-person -s and subject–verb agreement	GRA
4	Uncountables pluralised	GRA, arguably LR too
5	Faulty complex structures — <i>Although...but</i> , <i>despite</i> + clause, dangles, resumptives	GRA — this is the band-6 limiter
6	Prepositions	GRA
7	False friends and word-formation errors	LR
8	Tense consistency; <i>since</i> vs <i>for</i>	GRA
9	Copula omission	GRA
10	Linker overuse, over-formal register, repetition	CC / TR

Nothing on that list is a bolded rating-limiter in the descriptor grid — bold starts at band 5 — and nothing needs to be. Band 6 is defined by its positive features, and these are what stop you fitting band 7's.